

The Golden Rule

The idea of reciprocal respect as a model for human relationships is central to the moral philosophy of Confucius (see [Confucianism](#)). He also advocated reciprocity as a guide for our behaviour towards others: ‘what you do not desire for yourself, do not do to others’. Interestingly, Confucius presents this ‘ethic of reciprocity’ in a negative form (as do many Eastern religions), implying restraint rather than action, while in the West it is more familiar as the positive ‘do unto others as you would have them do unto you’. In one form or another, this maxim has featured in almost all major religions, and has been stated by many moral philosophers. Because of its universal acceptance, it has become known as the ‘Golden Rule’.

This concept is not only fundamental to ideas of ethics, but also has implications for political philosophy. Incorporating the principle into a system of government raises questions of how much its rule should impinge upon the lives of its citizens – how authoritarian or libertarian it should be.

JUDAISM



'Love thy neighbour
as thyself.'

BUDDHISM



'Hurt not others with that
which pains yourself.'

CHRISTIANITY



'Whatever you wish
people would do unto
you, so do unto them.'

HINDUISM



'People should always treat
others as they themselves
wish to be treated.'